

Enterprise AI Credits Governance Implementation Guide

Audience, scope, and outcomes

This guide is for customer budget owners, service owners, security teams, license managers, business owners, administrators, and assurance reviewers who govern usage-based AI services.

No software integration, source-code package, or particular assessment tool is required. Customers may use approved provider portals, exports, finance records, spreadsheets, scripts, or other approved tools. The method matters less than traceable sources, accountable decisions, controlled changes, and verified outcomes.

AI Credit (AIC) means the provider-defined unit used to measure eligible AI consumption. User-Level Budget (ULB) means a customer-defined per-user spending or consumption boundary where the provider supports one. Confirm both terms against current provider documentation before adopting them.

The governance process should produce:

- A defined scope and accountable ownership model
- A reconciled consumption, entitlement, and cost baseline
- Configurable financial, user, cohort, and access-policy controls
- Approved profile assignments with evidence and review dates
- Tested alert, enforcement, exception, and rollback procedures
- An operating cadence that keeps records aligned with verified provider state

Important: Confirm current rates, entitlements, data availability, supported controls, control scope, precedence, alerts, and enforcement behavior from authoritative provider records and documentation. Use controlled tests to verify behavior in the customer environment before relying on any control.

Governance architecture and workflow

Provider-neutral AI consumption governance

■ evidence ■ control ■ approval ■ monitoring

Customer-owned route: scope -> evidence -> configurable controls -> approval -> pilot -> operation

1

Define scope, authority, and decision ownership

Define the decision

Account, service, population, period, and exclusions.

Name accountable owners

Budget, service, security, license, business, and operating owners.

Set decision rights

Evidence handling, change, exception, rollback, and escalation paths.

2

Register evidence and establish the baseline

Authoritative provider evidence

Consumption, entitlement, capability, and configured state.

Source register

Owner, scope, retrieval time, authorization, condition, limitations.

Customer and finance evidence

Funding, inventory, assignments, need, risk, and scoped variances.

3

Decide whether evidence is complete enough

Decision gate

Complete enough for the decision and approval?

Continue

Reconcile the scoped baseline and preserve warnings.

No: resolve or limit

Record Unknown, gap owner, impact, approver, or defer.

4

Design four separate configurable layers

Enterprise guardrail

Financial backstop for aggregate metered exposure.

Per-user controls

Universal baseline plus approved cohort overrides.

Access-policy archetype

Separate access posture from financial controls and limits.

Controlled profile register: scope, assignment, owner, evidence, response, duration, and review date.

5

Validate behavior, design, and approval

Validate with documentation and tests

Rates, capability, scope, overlap, precedence, alerts, and enforcement.

Owners approve?

Yes: approve limited pilot.
No: revise or defer.

Alerts are signals

They do not by themselves block usage or approve change.

6

Pilot, stage rollout, and operate

Limited pilot

Prior state, measures, support, rollback.

Stage rollout waves

Verify each approved assignment.

Operate verified state

Maintain records and support users.

7

Monitor, respond, reconcile, and improve

Consumption, cost, assignment, access posture, drift

Early warning: refresh and notify.

Critical or limit: escalate, contain, roll back.

Customer-owned governance: verify provider behavior, preserve evidence, and repeat review when conditions change.

Diagram [IG-EXT-01](#) summarizes the customer governance architecture and implementation workflow. The linked SVG is the maintained diagram asset.

This flow is a decision method, not a guarantee of provider precedence or enforcement.

Evidence foundations

Evidence source register

Maintain a customer-owned register for every source used in a decision. A source is usable only when its owner, scope, retrieval time, and limitations are known.

Field	Record
Source ID	Stable customer identifier
Source and owner	Provider record, finance record, approved export, or other owned source
Scope	Account, organization, population, service, period, and exclusions
Retrieval method	Approved portal, export, query, spreadsheet, script, or other method
Retrieval time	Timestamp and applicable billing or reporting period
Authorization	Access basis and responsible operator
Data condition	Complete, partial, delayed, unavailable, or disputed
Known limitations	Coverage gaps, field definitions, aggregation, latency, or permissions
Evidence location	Controlled location and retention classification
Review date	Next owner validation

Compact baseline worksheet

Use one worksheet per approved scope. Add rows when provider or finance records distinguish additional services, populations, or charging paths.

Measure	Value or status	Source ID	As of	Owner	Variance or limitation
Eligible licenses					
Assigned licenses					
Included entitlement					
Gross measured consumption					
Included consumption					
Metered consumption					
Recorded cost					
Forecast exposure					
Existing control coverage					

Record unknown values as **Unknown** , not as zero. Record zero only when an authoritative source completed successfully, covered the intended scope, and explicitly returned no measured value.

Configurable governance model

Design four separate layers. Values, scope, and behavior remain customer decisions supported by current evidence and controlled tests.

Layer	Control	Purpose	Required decision evidence
1	Enterprise financial guardrail	Bounds aggregate financial exposure for the approved scope	Forecast, risk tolerance, funding owner, and provider capability
2	Universal per-user baseline	Establishes the default boundary for eligible users	Population need, expected usage, interruption tolerance, and cost
3	Approved higher-usage cohort override	Grants a different boundary to a justified, owned cohort	Business need, duration, forecast exposure, and review date
4	Organization access-policy archetype	Defines approved access posture for features and service options	Security, entitlement, data handling, ownership, and validation

The organization access-policy archetype is separate from budgets. Do not infer access rights from a financial limit or infer a financial limit from an access-policy assignment. Record, approve, test, and review the two decisions independently.

Before choosing precedence among layers, confirm the provider's current scope and inheritance behavior. Test overlapping assignments, alert delivery, limit transitions, and enforcement in a controlled population.

Roles and prerequisites

Role	Accountability
Executive sponsor	Accepts risk posture and material unresolved exceptions
Enterprise budget owner	Approves financial exposure, response options, and variance
Service owner	Owns the method, registers, evidence, reviews, and control health
Security owner	Approves access posture, data handling, and compensating controls
License owner	Validates eligibility, entitlement, inventory, and assignment
Business owner	Confirms need, affected population, duration, and interruption risk
Cohort or cost owner	Accepts cohort membership, funding, and review obligations
Authorized administrator	Applies and verifies approved provider changes
Assurance reviewer	Reviews evidence, approvals, reconciliation, and control operation

Complete these prerequisites before design begins:

- Name role owners and escalation delegates
- Define account, organization, service, population, and period scope
- Approve evidence storage, retention, access, and data handling
- Confirm access to authoritative provider, license, and finance records
- Establish change, incident, exception, and rollback processes
- Define acceptable reconciliation tolerance and unresolved-data treatment
- Document current provider capabilities and planned controlled tests

Design and assignment criteria

Use customer evidence and explicit business decisions. Do not assign a profile solely because a user or group consumed more than an average.

Criterion	Decision question
Customer evidence	Are sources current, complete enough, owned, and reconciled?
Business need	What approved outcome requires this control or access posture?
Forecast exposure	What consumption and financial range is plausible during the term?
Interruption tolerance	What happens if alerts fire or usage is limited?
Security	Are data, feature, service, and integration risks accepted?
License eligibility	Is each person eligible and correctly entitled for the proposed profile?
Ownership	Who funds, approves, operates, supports, and reviews the assignment?
Duration	Is the assignment standing, temporary, pilot-only, or event-bound?
Review date	When must evidence, need, value, and provider behavior be reassessed?

Reject or defer an assignment when material evidence is unknown, ownership is missing, license eligibility is unresolved, or interruption impact has not been accepted.

Customer naming and profile register

Adopt names that follow the customer's approved naming method. Names should be unique within scope, stable enough for audit, and readable by operators. Keep the display name separate from the stable register ID so names can change without breaking history.

Profile field	Required content
Register ID	Stable customer-controlled identifier
Name and version	Approved display name and immutable version
Layer and scope	Governance layer, account boundary, and included population
Assignment rule	Explicit eligibility, exclusions, and duplicate-handling rule
Value and unit	Approved boundary, period, currency or measure, and effective date
Access posture	Approved options and restrictions, recorded separately from budget
Owners and approvers	Business, budget, security, license, and operating accountability
Evidence references	Source, reconciliation, decision, test, and change records
Response settings	Trigger definitions, recipients, actions, and escalation path
Duration and review	Start, expiry when applicable, and next review date
Status	Proposed, pilot, active, suspended, retired, or rolled back
Prior version	Previous active record and restoration reference

Lifecycle phases

Each phase is a gate. Record a named owner for every unresolved action before moving forward.

Phase	Owners	Actions	Evidence	Exit criteria
Prepare	Service, budget, security, and license	Set scope, roles, sources, handling, tests, success measures, and rollback	Scope, role matrix, source plan, and test plan	Owners accept scope, authority, evidence handling, and decision rights
Baseline	Service, budget, license, and administrator	Collect sources, mark gaps, reconcile totals, and document variances	Source register, worksheet, and reconciliation record	Required values are reconciled or limitations are formally accepted
Design	Service, business, budget, security, license	Propose four-layer profiles, assignments, responses, names, and reviews	Draft profile register and impact assessment	Every proposal has evidence, rationale, owner, duration, and review
Approve	Budget, security, license, business, sponsor	Decide each profile, exception, pilot, support path, and change record	Decisions, approvals, exceptions, and authorized change	Each proposal is approved, rejected, or returned with a named owner
Pilot	Pilot lead, administrator, service, support	Capture prior state, apply a limited change, test, monitor, and reconcile	Before and after state, tests, measures, and feedback	Success and tolerance criteria are met, or rollback is completed
Rollout	Service, administrator, change, and business	Sequence waves, reconfirm evidence, communicate, apply, verify, and pause	Wave records, verification, communications, and register	In-scope assignments match the active register and ownership is clear
Operate	Service, budget, security, license, business	Review, reconcile, resolve alerts, control changes, and retire profiles	Reviews, incidents, changes, exceptions, and trends	Controls operate on schedule and verified state matches the register

Monitoring and response

Set triggers from customer risk tolerance, forecast uncertainty, lead time, and validated provider behavior. Do not assume that an alert blocks usage or that a displayed limit is enforced.

Stage	Configurable trigger	Response	Evidence
Early warning	Customer-selected signal that leaves response lead time	Validate data, refresh forecast, notify owners, and confirm need	Alert, owner acknowledgement, data check, and new forecast
Critical	Customer-selected signal requiring an owner decision	Escalate, assess continuity, choose action, and communicate	Decision, impact assessment, approval, and communication
Limit reached	Verified boundary event or equivalent provider state	Follow tested enforcement, incident, exception, or rollback path	Provider event, action record, approval, and reconciliation

For each stage, record trigger logic, source, evaluation frequency, recipients, acknowledgement target, decision authority, supported actions, and fallback communication. Validate alert timing and delivery with controlled tests.

Reconciliation and data quality

Use this procedure whenever sources disagree or coverage changes:

1. Preserve the original records, timestamps, scope, and warnings.
2. Classify each value by source and distinguish measured, calculated, forecast, and manually confirmed values.
3. Confirm period, account scope, population, service, entitlement, and rate basis from authoritative records.
4. Compare provider totals with finance, license, organization, and cohort records without treating unlike measures as interchangeable.
5. Separate expected coverage differences from unexplained variance.

6. Record the variance, cause, owner, tolerance decision, and due date.
7. Recalculate forecasts and reassess assignments with reconciled inputs.
8. Block approval when unknown data could change eligibility, exposure, precedence, interruption impact, or enforcement decisions.

Treat failed, unauthorized, unsupported, delayed, hidden, or partial results as unknown. Never convert them to zero, an empty population, or evidence of no consumption.

Exceptions, change control, and rollback

Every exception must record the affected profile and population, business reason, risk, compensating controls, forecast impact, approvers, start, expiry, review date, and rollback trigger.

Use this change procedure:

1. Link the request to the active profile version and evidence baseline.
2. Capture current provider state and a tested restoration method.
3. Assess financial, security, entitlement, business, support, and interruption effects.
4. Obtain required approvals and create the proposed register version.
5. Validate through a controlled test or approved pilot.
6. Have an authorized administrator apply the approved change.
7. Independently verify scope, precedence, alerts, and enforcement behavior.
8. Observe for the approved period and reconcile results.
9. Close the change only after evidence and the active register agree.

Roll back when assignment is wrong, access is unauthorized, interruption is unexpected, variance exceeds tolerance, evidence is incomplete, or approved success criteria fail. Restore the captured prior provider state and prior active register version. Preserve decision, incident, test, and reconciliation history.

Review cadence

Choose the cadence that matches exposure and operating maturity. More than one cadence can apply.

Option	Review focus
Weekly	Active alerts, pilots, high-exposure cohorts, incidents, and exceptions
Monthly	Entitlements, consumption, cost, forecast, assignments, and reconciliation
Quarterly	Profile design, access posture, ownership, evidence, training, and drift
Event-driven	Rate, entitlement, feature, organization, risk, incident, or control change

At each review, confirm that source availability, rates, supported controls, scope, precedence, alert behavior, and enforcement assumptions remain current.

Getting-started checklist

1. Name the service, budget, security, license, business, and operating owners.
2. Define the first account, population, service, and reporting period.
3. Create the evidence source register and baseline worksheet.
4. Reconcile entitlement, consumption, cost, and existing control coverage.
5. Document provider-validation questions and controlled tests.

- 6. Draft one profile for each needed governance layer.
- 7. Approve a limited pilot, success measures, communications, and rollback.
- 8. Run the pilot, reconcile results, and decide whether to revise or roll out.
- 9. Start the selected review cadence and keep the active register current.

Evidence checklist

Before approving a profile or closing a change, confirm the evidence set has:

- Defined scope, owners, period, exclusions, and authorization context
- Current provider documentation and authoritative records used for decisions
- Completed source register with limitations and retrieval timestamps
- Reconciled baseline and approved variance treatment
- Profile version, assignment rationale, values, owners, and review dates
- Business, budget, security, license, and operating approvals as applicable
- Controlled test results for scope, precedence, alerts, and enforcement
- Exception records with compensating controls and expiry
- Prior state, approved change, independent verification, and observation record
- Communications, incidents, rollback actions, and post-change reconciliation

Glossary

Term	Definition
AI Credit (AIC)	Provider-defined unit for eligible AI consumption
User-Level Budget (ULB)	Customer-defined per-user boundary where supported
Financial guardrail	Approved control intended to bound aggregate financial exposure
Cohort override	Time-bound or standing profile for an approved higher-usage population
Access-policy archetype	Reusable access posture managed separately from financial controls
Profile register	Controlled record of profile versions, assignments, owners, and evidence
Reconciliation	Comparison that explains differences among authoritative and derived records
Unknown	Value that cannot be established from a complete, authorized source
Controlled test	Limited validation of actual provider behavior under approved conditions
Rollback	Restoration of the captured prior provider state and active profile version